is losing her sense of self because of dementia, and Koechlin as Anamika, who comes to rediscover her Indian identity while caring for her mother.

Having loved Kripalani's directorial debut film *The Threshold* (2015), Koechlin knew she wanted to work with him, but it was *Goldfish's* script, written by Kripalani and Arghya Lahiri, that made her sign on the dotted line. "It's a very moving script. Arghya is someone I know well and his father had dementia and I think a lot of the story was inspired from the experiences of his family. It's a very tangible and real story." After premiering at the Busan Film Festival (October 5-15), *Goldfish* will travel to the Raindance Film Festival (October 26-Novemeber 5), which is a BAFTA- and Oscar-qualifying festival.

Since filming *Goldfish*, Koechlin, 38, has also wrapped filming the second season of the hit show *Made in Heaven* and the film *Kho Gaye Hum Kahan*. She has recorded the third season of *My Indian Life*, a BBC podcast that explores compelling stories about young Indians. She even made her debut as an author last December with *Elephant in the Womb*, a raw and sometimes funny account of her pregnancy: "It was therapeutic at the time to keep a journal, to just keep a creative element going because through the lockdown and motherhood, I just didn't know who I was anymore." ■

Karishma Upadhyay



DOCTOR G
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While Ayushmann Khurrana tends to make the right career choices, his characters are often caught in the wrong jobs. Here, for instance, the actor plays a reticent gynaecology student.

Living the Fantasy Life

With Netflix adapting his popular fantasy series, author Soman Chainani is campaigning for a darker and edgier fairytale

Netflix recently released the trailer for its upcoming fantasy film *The School for Good and Evil*, directed by Paul Feig. In it, we see Sofia Wylie and Sophia Ann Caruso star as Agatha and Sophie, best friends who are whisked away to the titular school for a series of magical adventures. The two young actresses are backed up by several A-listers: Laurence Fishburne, Michelle Yeoh, Charlize Theron, Ben Kingsley et al.

The film is based on the eponymous 2013 novel by American author Soman Chainani, 43, which sold millions of copies and spawned five sequels (and a prequel earlier this year). These books were written in part as a response to the fairytales (and their Disney versions) that Chainani read while growing up, narratives he felt were far more 'squeaky-clean' compared to their medieval forebears. During a video interview, Chainani said: "When I was at Harvard, I took a fairytale class. Up until that point, I knew only the Disney versions of these stories, but now, week after week, we would read the original, darker versions of these fairytales, written hundreds of years ago. Ultimately, I felt like there was room to bring back some of these older versions."

Through the course of Sophie and Agatha's adventures, their equations with the Schools (there's a School for Good and a different School for Evil) keep changing; these schools are not 'safe havens', like Hogwarts is for Harry Potter and his friends. Chainani says, "It is funny because a lot of what I was writing initially was based on my reaction to the Harry Potter series. Though I loved the books, I felt they were structured in the familiar Disney way where the good guy always wins. I wanted to create a middle school where the experience felt a little edgy, a little dangerous, like one actually does feel in middle school!"

Chainani came out as gay during college and he feels strongly about the role of fantasy fiction in the lives of young queer people. "Fantasy fiction has always helped queer people realise their true selves. My world is not a world with labels or constricting identities."

"I WANTED TO CREATE A MIDDLE SCHOOL WHERE THE EXPERIENCE FELT A LITTLE EDGY, A LITTLE DANGEROUS, LIKE ONE ACTUALLY FEELS IN MIDDLE SCHOOL"

The author, whose parents come from Mumbai, grew up in Florida, reading a lot of Indian folktales. "I went to Gita classes," Chainani recalls. He still visits Mumbai frequently and, at one point, was supposed to direct an English-language movie shot in India. "After that project kept getting delayed, I started work on what would become *The School for Good and Evil*." According to the author, Indian folktales and myths have "a quality of mischief and playfulness that stories from other parts of the world often do not". He says, "I have a character called 'Ravan' in the first book. It is a younger version, but everybody knows who it really is!" ■

Aditya Mani Jha



IRVIN RIVERA